Digestive & Bowel Health

Core Principle

Digestion and elimination depend more on rhythm, nervous system state, and mechanical efficiency than on stimulation or diet. When digestion is impaired, simplify, regularize, and down-regulate first before adding herbs or laxatives.

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1. Foundational Digestion Aids (Non-Negotiable)

A. Circadian Regularity

- Eat and sleep at the same times every day, including weekends.
- Largest meal at midday, lightest meal in the evening.
- Avoid eating after 7 pm.
    - If necessary: steamed vegetables, ripe bananas, or soup only.

Why: Digestive enzyme secretion, bile flow, and colonic motility are circadian-regulated.

B. Nervous System State

- Never eat when stressed, rushed, angry, or emotionally dysregulated.
- Pause 5–10 minutes before and after meals:
    - slow breathing
    - brief gratitude or sensory grounding
    - smell and visually engage with food

Why: The cephalic phase of digestion begins with perception. Sympathetic dominance suppresses stomach acid, enzymes, and bile.

C. Mindful Eating Mechanics

- Eat seated, undistracted.
- Chew thoroughly until food is nearly liquid.
- Stop eating before fullness (≈70–80%).
- Sitting in Vajrasana after meals aids digestion.

D. Food Order & Combination

To reduce bloating, gas, and bacterial overgrowth:

1. Watery/light foods first (fruit, soups) → allow ample time for digestion
2. Denser/heavier food last

Specific aids:

- Leafy greens before cooked meals → enzyme priming and smoother gastric transition.
- Citrus fruits: at least 1 hour before or after meals, never with heavy food.
- Always eat nuts soaked and combined with dried fruits to ease digestion.
- Avoid mixing:
    - fruit + heavy proteins
    - starch + sugar in the same meal

      → for further info see *Food Combination* document

E. Fluids

- Stay well hydrated during the day.
- Drink 5-15 minutes before meals, not during or within 1 hour after.
- Small sips during meals only if absolutely needed.

Why: Excess liquid dilutes gastric acid and delays stomach emptying.

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2. Foods: What to Emphasize & Avoid

Foods to Eat Daily (if tolerated)

- Ripe bananas
- Cucumbers / cucumber juice
- Leafy greens
- Steamed vegetables

Foods to Avoid or Minimize

- Leftovers (especially >24 hours)
- Processed or ultra-refined foods
- Cold, iced, or raw foods when digestion is weak
- Excess snacking between meals

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3. Herbs & Supplements

- Trikatu – warming, stimulating (contraindicated with heat, inflammation, anxiety)
- Triphala guggulu – bowel + detox support (short-term)
- Digestive bitters – bile and appetite regulation
- Digestive enzymes – functional insufficiency only

Note: Not every herb suits every constitution or condition.
Dose, timing, and combinations matter.

Daily Gentle Supports

- Aloe vera juice: 10–50 ml, empty stomach
  → hydrates, softens stool
- Organic celery + cucumber juice each morning before food

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4. Healthy Bowel Habits (Elimination Hygiene)

Optimal Bowel Movement Characteristics

- First bowel movement in the morning
- 2–3 bowel movements per day
- No straining
- Swift, effortless passage
- Minimal odor
- Ideally little or no toilet paper required

(Transit time varies on food and metabolism; 12–24 hours is common.*)*

Training the Bowel

- Wake at consistent time
- Drink warm water upon rising
- Sit on toilet before / after breakfast—even without urge
- Use a toilet chair to mimic squatting

Why: Colonic motility is strongest in the morning and post-meal (gastro-colic reflex).

Movement & Yogic Self-Care

- Daily walking

- Kryias: Agnisara, nauli, uddiyana bandha (only if appropriate)
- Gentle backbends and twists
- Abdominal self-massage
- Epsom salt baths for relaxation and magnesium absorption

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5. What Improves Bowel Movement

- Regular meal timing
- Adequate hydration
- Soluble fiber (not excess insoluble fiber)
- Magnesium sufficiency
- Parasympathetic tone
- Morning movement
- Early, light dinner or skipping dinner if needed

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6. What Compromises Bowel Movement

- Irregular eating or sleeping
- Suppressed emotions
- Chronic stress or urgency
- Eating late at night
- Overuse of laxatives
- Dehydration
- Excess protein without fiber or fat balance
- Ignoring natural urges
- Sitting too long

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7. Effect of Different Foods on Bowel Movement

Loosening / Promoting

- Ripe fruits
- Dried fruits
- Cooked vegetables

- Healthy fats
- Warm liquids
- Simple meals with no unnecessary ingredients

Slowing / Hardening

- Excess dairy
- Excessive and unsoaked nuts / nut butters
- Dry bread
- Red meat without vegetables
- Dehydrating foods
- Cold/raw food when digestion is weak
- Complex meals with too many ingredients

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8. Natural Laxatives (Use Only When Needed)

Gentle Daily Options

- Drinking 1l of water in one gulp (before food)
- Soaked chia seeds, flaxseeds, or psyllium husk
- Aloe vera juice

Fruit-Based

- Banana-smoothie (5-10 bananas)
- Kiwi (3/day)
- Soaked prunes (10 before meals) or figs
- Bananas (4 for breakfast)
- Cucumber or cucumber juice
- Melon for dinner (to encourage early morning motion)

Stronger Measures (Short-Term Only)

- Herbal enemas (e.g. triphala, dashamula)
  → only after several days of constipation
- Castor oil packs on lower abdomen before bed

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9. Functional Food Attitudes

Choose foods that digest easily, maintain stable energy, support sleep, and allow regular bowel movement.

- Be gentle with yourself. Trying to eat perfectly and being obsessed with food and the digestive process defeats the purpose.
- Always transition gradually and over a period of weeks in and out of diets so that the gutbiome can adapt to the changes.
- Appropriate individual diet is not rigid but a needs to be constantly adjusted to lifestyle, season, physiological obstruction and digestive capacity. It is inspired by Spirit, i.e. it supports deeper awareness, not mental concepts or identities.
- If a food causes bloating, fatigue, anxiety, reflux, or constipation, it is not appropriate at that time, no matter how healthy it is supposed to be.
- During digestive instability, keep meals simple and repetitive; introduce variety only when stable.
- Judge foods by delayed effects (hours later, next morning), not immediate sensations.
- Avoid aggressive interventions; excess fiber, bitters, or detoxing can worsen digestion.
- Try your best not to use food to regulate emotions or override nervous system dysregulation.
- Dietary flexibility and occasional deviation are needed for gutbiome variety and a healthy gut.

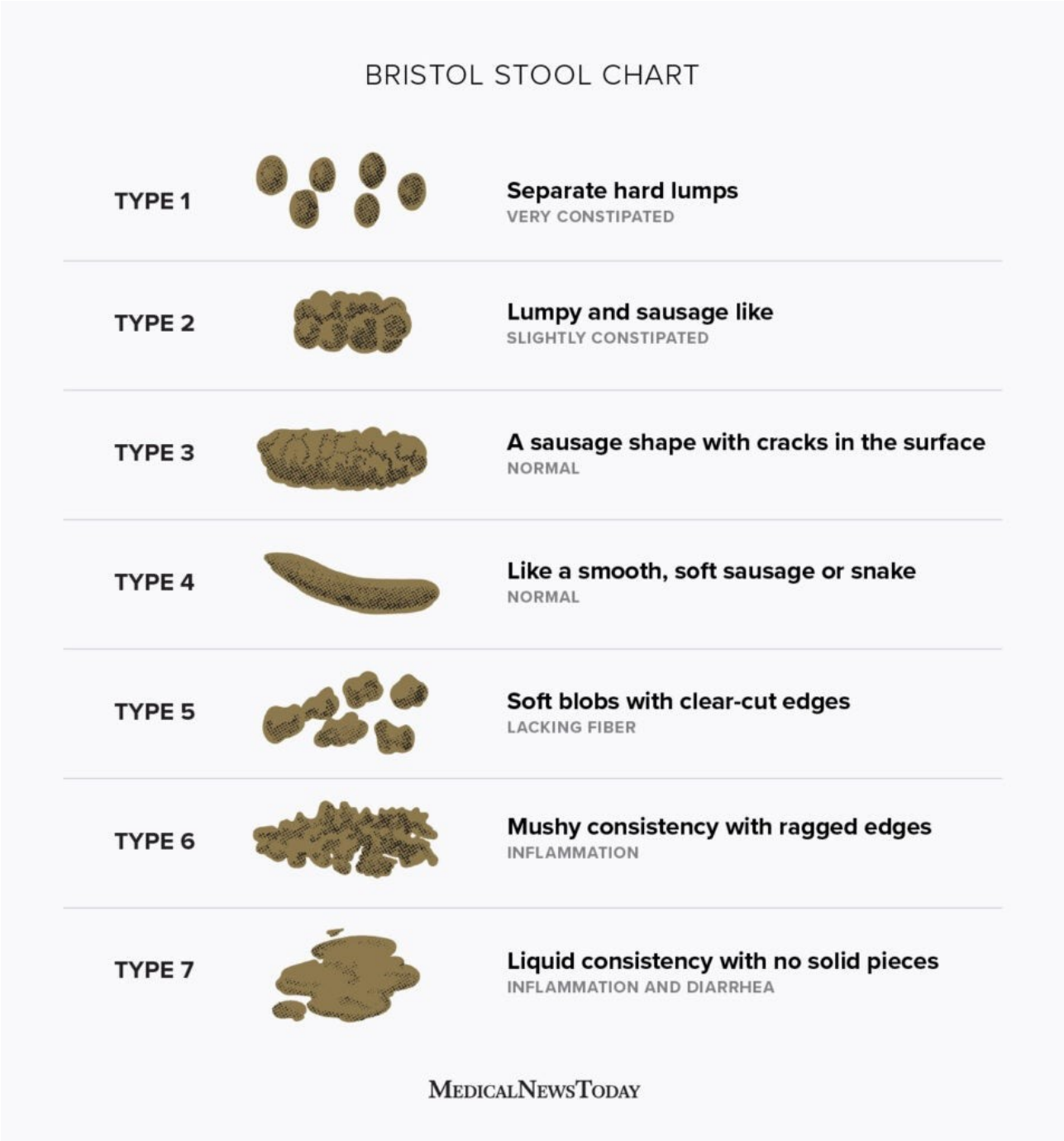
Bottom line:
If eating requires constant control or correction, digestion is likely compromised regardless of food quality.

Final Thought

Healthy digestion and elimination emerge from: rhythm, containment and listening, rather than force, stimulation and fixing.

Laxatives and herbs are supports, not foundations. If bowel health does not normalize with rhythm, simplicity, and nervous system regulation, reassess for deeper functional or structural causes.

Appendix: Bristol Stool Chart



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